



ced Gemini and Perplexity with this underrated AI tool



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By [Nolen Jonker](#) — Feb 26, 2026, 4:30 PM EST



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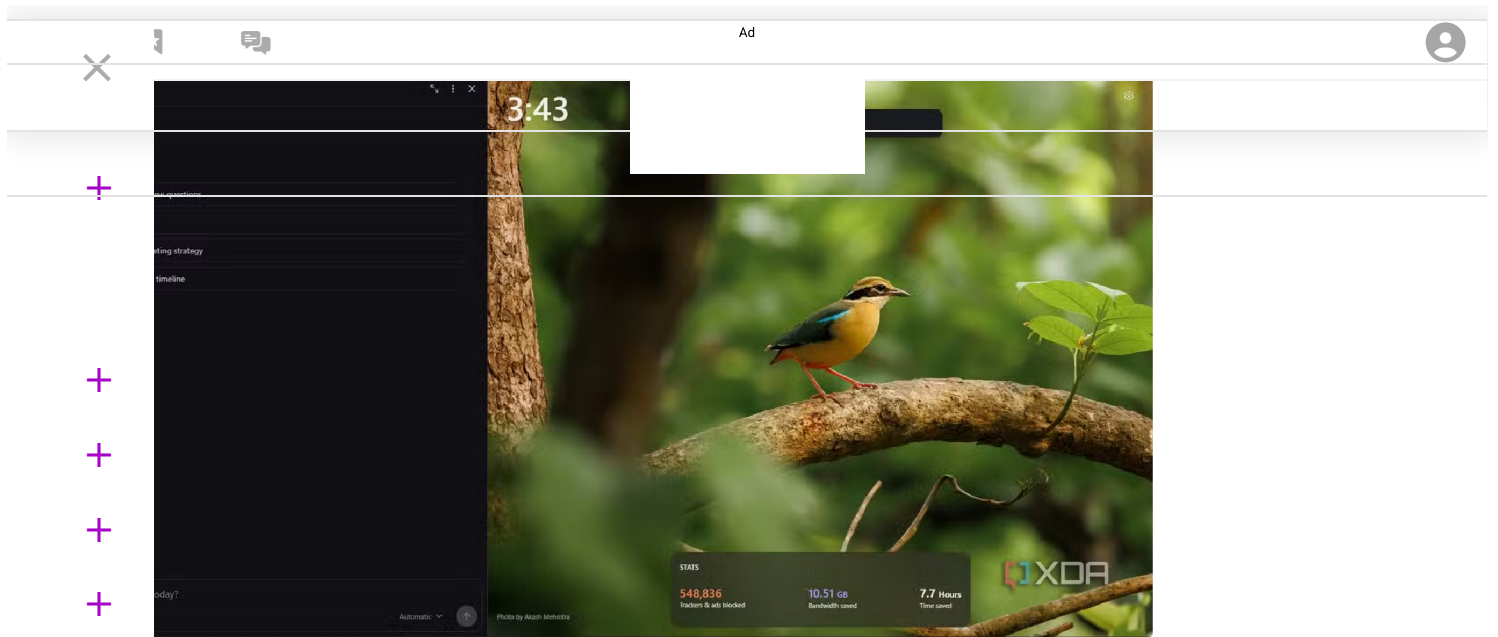
AI tool I’ve been sleeping on quite a bit that has been right under my nose this entire time, and the issue of tool-hopping once I gave it a real shot. I’m talking about my regular browser’s in-
Brave Leo. This AI chatbot handles everything I actually need in one place, with the added
day-first assistance. Here’s how it can replace tools like Gemini and Perplexity for a daily

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actly is Leo?

Integration



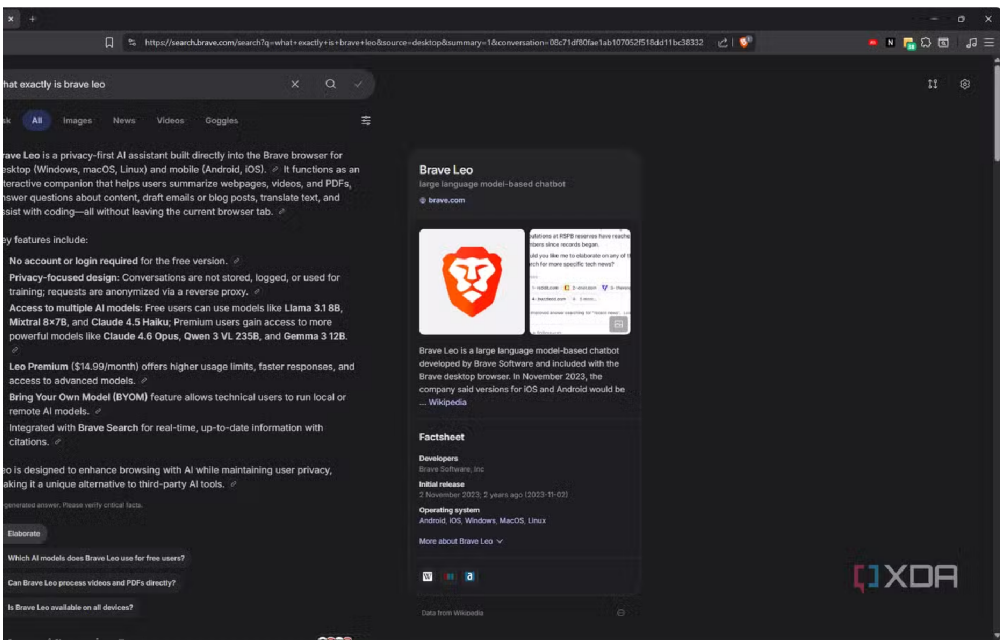
is an AI tool built directly into the Brave browser, not a separate app or extension. It lives in the address bar (though this is customizable), so you can interact with AI while you're browsing. It's also possible to jump to another tab or service. Technically, it works as a browser-native interface that can parse the content of any page you're on and let you ask questions about it, summarize it, translate it, or extract relevant material without leaving the tab. But it also has its own separate, full-page interface that is accessible independently of your current tabs.

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Instead of a single model, it's more like a routing layer that connects to multiple LLMs such as Mixtral, GPT-4o, Claude, depending on the setup or tier you're using (I'm using the free tier with most of the configurations). Brave hosts these models on its own infrastructure for privacy, so your data isn't sent to the model creators. It also has a "bring your own model" feature, so you can plug in local models on your machine or connect to external APIs.

Leo's design is privacy. Requests are anonymized, chats aren't retained on Brave's servers, responses are discarded after they're generated. Chat history can be stored locally on your device if you want that way, though. Overall, Leo is aimed at people who want AI integrated directly into their browsing. Instead of opening separate AI tools, the browser itself becomes the interface for asking questions, analyzing pages, and working with information.

Brave Leo replaces Perplexity for browsing search



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people. Perplexity is an AI search engine that basically replaces traditional search entirely. Leo

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lling in real-time search data, and present it a

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ice to Perplexity is that Leo is an optional AI layer rather than a standalone search engine. I can tional search, then bring in Leo to ask questions about any page I'm on whenever I want. It's ave's interface and its visibility is customizable - I don't have Leo's panel enabled by default, it from the hamburger menu whenever I need to, or just rely on the summary with the chat top of my searches. There's no jump between searching, researching, and learning as there is exity + Gemini combo.

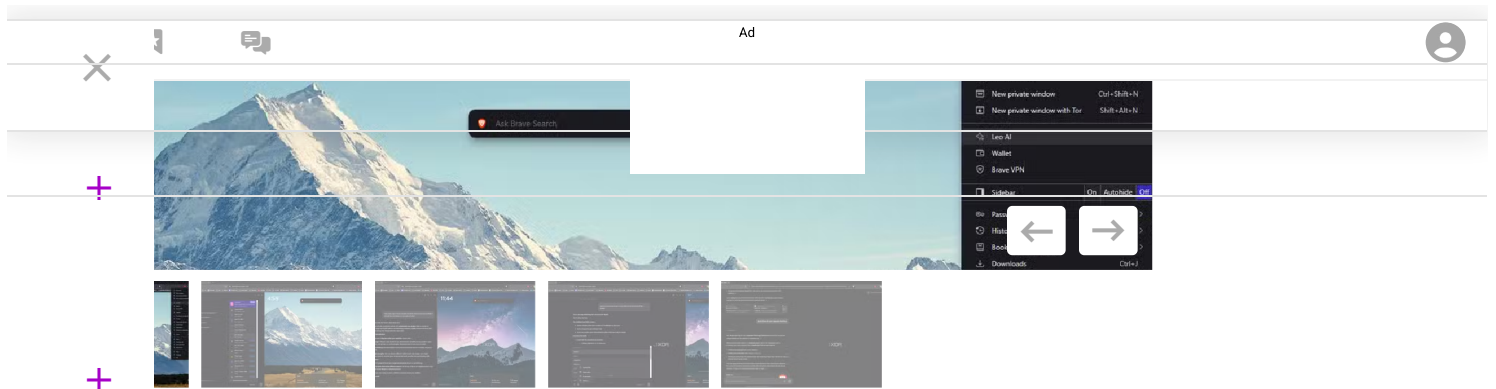
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s how it reflects what's actually going on on the internet. The information itself can still be : top results themselves are wrong, but Leo's summaries always line up closely with what : say. And this is what follow-up questions in the chat panel are for: to pull in second opinions nalyze different results.

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eo replaces Gemini
y everyday chatbot routine



e Leo shifts to being a full chatbot. While I primarily use the Leo chatbot in the search results
 has its own interface that you can use independently in a separate window. This is what I use
 work or when I need more conversational responses. I also love that I don't have to be precise
 I'm looking for since it's excellent at inferring what I mean, plus, it still pulls from real-time

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e comes with a couple of presets such as "explain" and "paraphrase" for quick queries. And it
 bad documents, using retrieval augmented generation that enables you to interact with those
 Brave's privacy-forward philosophy shows up with controls like "temporary chat". Moreover,
 custom Skills that you can build to perform certain repetitive tasks; they're kind of like Gemini

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better

Perplexity are by no means bad, but Brave's Leo does the same things, with the added
 of already being integrated into my daily browser, which I practically live in. Plus, it's a lot

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